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The Duffing of Eunice Powell

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THE DUFFING OF EUNICE POWELL

TED

(looking around,

whisper-shouting)

Hey! Eunice!

EUNICE

Ted?

TED

Eunice, I have a question. A girl

question.

EUNICE

Then, why are you coming to me?

TED

I don't know.. you're a girl,

right?

EUNICE

Well, I mean, yeah. But people

don't really come to me for girl

help. They usually just use me for

chemistry answers.

TED

Speaking of which.. do you have

that study guide for me?

EUNICE

Oh! Yeah, here..

EUNICE pulls a sheet of paper out of her book bag, and hands

it to TED, trying to be cute.

TED

Thanks. Well, anyways. I came to

you because I didn't know who else

to talk too.

EUNICE

(feeling honored, trying to

act casual)

Oh. Well, what's up?

TED

So, there's this girl I like, okay?

And, um.. I don't really know how

to talk to her. I really want to

ask her out.

EUNICE

Ted, come on. All the girls like you. You're literally the most popular guy in our school. Like actually. You were actually voted that. Yet for some reason, I have more confidence than you, and I'm wearing maternity shorts right now.

TED

Well.. this girl is different. She's not my usual. And I don't know.. I'm just nervous about talking with her. She's really down to earth. And cool. And I've known her my whole life, and its just a lot of pressure.

EUNICE

(looks out to the audience, eyes widened, pointing to herself secretly, she thinks TED is talking about her)

Ted, come on. This girl is probably head over heels for you! You're so cool. You should just go for it. I'm sure she couldn't refuse you.

TED

(gaining his confidence back)

Oh. Well, thanks Eunice. That's good advice. I'm gonna go find her right now! See you later!

EUNICE

Wait! Where are you going? I'm right here.

TED

(confused)

What do you mean?

There is awkward silence.

TED

(realizing)

Ohhhhhhhhhh. You thought... I was talking about.... you....

EUNICE

Well.. I mean, yeah.

TED

(laughing)

Well, no offense, Eunice... but

you're a duff. I'd never like you.

Its okay, though, I forgive you for

thinking that.

EUNICE

Oh, wow. Thanks.

TED

(obviously oblivious to

EUNICE's feelings)

No problem! Thanks for the advice!

And thanks for the study guide,

too. I'll let you know what she

says!

EUNICE

(waving, fake, knowing TED

won't notice)

Mmmhmm! Yeah! Please do!

EUNICE steps out of the scene, and takes us to her own

narrative story-scape.

EUNICE

I always knew I was different. At

the ripe age of seven, I consumed

twelve crayons, sending me straight

to the emergency room. They almost pumped my stomach, but instead preferred for me to stay fully clothed. At nine, Peter Frances told me I had the best mustache in the class. By fourteen, I fully realized my deep love of Cape Cod potato chips and cosmic brownies. It was at this point I realized I was not like most girls. So when, as a freshman in high school, the kids in my class jokingly told me to try out for the football team, I couldn't refuse, momentarily forgetting my poor hand-eye coordination and my complete and total lack of athleticism altogether.

TED yells "ten hut!!!", turning around and piking the ball, throwing it at EUNICE. She gets hit in the face, and yells "ouch!". TED comes over and kicks EUNICE, not knowing it is her.

EUNICE

(feeling her nose, which TED kicked)

Nooooo! I have a deviated septum!

TED

Eunice? Is that you?

EUNICE

Pause.

EUNICE steps out of this scene, going back to that "story-scape". TED remains frozen.

EUNICE

This is Ted. Ted and I have gone to the same summer camp, Freeman's Outdoor Excursion for Young Men, for almost seven years now. True, I am neither a young man nor enjoy the outdoors. But, my parents blindly signed me up for the cheapest, and most character-building camp they could find in the 1987 version of the Yellow Pages we still keep in our house. However, because of the bowl-cut I received the prior summer, none of the staff or counselors noticed that I was, in

fact, a girl, living among hundreds

of "young men". I first met Ted in

a pottery class I took summer of

'09. We were seated next to each

other, and I was having trouble

with my pottery wheel.

EUNICE struggles with a pottery wheel, and TED comes over to "help".

TED

(fake chivalrous at first)

Here, let me help you with that.

EUNICE

Oh.. thanks.

TED takes a handful of clay and throws it at EUNICE. EUNICE is shocked at first, but then throws a handful back at TED.

EUNICE

Time for Ted to get fed!

TED

Oh really? Time for... wait. I

don't think I even know your name.

EUNICE

(extending her hand)

Eunice.

TED

Ha! That's a weird name for a boy.

EUNICE

Right? Good thing I'm a girl!

TED scrunches his eyebrows, then shakes it off, obviously not caring.

EUNICE steps out again.

EUNICE

(excited, as if this is a dear memory)

That was the first day Ted found out I was a girl. For some reason, this fact never interfered- probably because at the time I looked so much like a boy I'm certain it was ingrained from then on in his mind to treat me like one. Ever since then, camp has been a reunion of friendship. But for

some reason, school is different.

We barely talk, if we talk at all.

The main reason for this can be

found in the yearbook. Last year,

Ted was not only Homecoming Prince,

but was also voted Best to Bring

Home to Your Parents and Most

Likely to Win the Lottery. I was

Treasurer of the Yodeling Club, and

won Most Likely to Own a Zaxby's

Franchise.

EUNICE takes us back to the football field.

TED

(looks around, noticing no one

there, but still clearly

ashamed he's talking to

EUNICE)

Hey, uh, are you alright? I think

I'm seeing brain matter coming out

of your nose.

EUNICE

(still feeling her nose,

acting a little woozy, getting

lost in Ted's eyes)

Yeah, yeah. It's fine. I'm fine.

You're fine. You're so fine.

TED

(reaching towards EUNICE's face, this is all very un-romantic.. but EUNICE doesn't fail to romanticize it.)

You've got some blood on your eyeball. Here, let me get it. You know, football wasn't your brightest idea.

EUNICE steps out again.

EUNICE

The way he looked at me with those dark brown eyes, it was like 800 milligrams of Ibuprofen for my deviated septum. The way the wind blew his hair just so.. the way--

SELF-ESTEEM

(snapping)

Eunice! Snap out of it! What are you thinking? His eyes aren't even

brown! They're that weird, murky

color you don't like.

SELF-ESTEEM is a character inside of EUNICE'S story-scape. It is very small, with a tiny voice, and EUNICE has to squint her eyes to see it.

EUNICE

(looking around)

What? Who's talking? Who are you?

SELF-ESTEEM

(waving arms)

I'm right here. It's me. You. I'm you. I'm your self-esteem.

EUNICE

(squinting)

My self-esteem? I didn't even know you existed.

SELF-ESTEEM

Yep. Barely. I've been here this whole time, in some form or another. Sadly, ever since your classmates started calling you Eunice Bowels (pronounced eu-NICE

bowels), I've shrunk to almost non-existence.. but I've managed to stick around this long.

EUNICE

Well, what are you doing here?

SELF-ESTEEM

I came here to warn you. I'd like to not shrink into extinct-ness, which would require you to not get involved with that boy.

EUNICE

Well, why? Its all innocent. We're friends. And he's nice to me. At least he doesn't call me Eu-nice Bowels.

SELF-ESTEEM

Yeah, that's because he doesn't know what that word means.

EUNICE

(starts to defend TED)

I--

SELF-ESTEEM

Come on, Eunice, a hermit crab has a higher IQ than him. (Pause) Look at yourself. You and I both know you've seen When Harry Met Sally way too many times to think men and women can just be friends.

EUNICE

Its possible! Its totally possible. Especially if the man in question thinks you're of the same sex.

SELF-ESTEEM

Eunice, we've been over this. You're a duff. You are not allowed to say the word "sex", in any context. You are merely a transitional form in Darwin's theory of evolution.

EUNICE

Aren't you supposed to be helping my self-esteem?

SELF-ESTEEM

No. I am your self-esteem, which

means I can literally say whatever
I want. I am only a reflection of
how you view yourself.

EUNICE

Oh, phew. I was beginning to think
I had voices in my head.

SELF-ESTEEM

Oh no you do. Its pretty crowded up
there.

EUNICE

Well what would you have me do?

SELF-ESTEEM

Well, in a year, you'll finish
high-school, possibly even
graduating at the top of your
class. If this is so, you will get
bullied. Then, after college, you
will look for a minimum-wage job to
aid you in paying off your college
debt while you move back in with
your parents. At the local Rite-Aid
where you work, you will possibly
meet a fellow male duff like

yourself, and give birth to little dufflings. At the age of 35, you will begin to question the meaning of life, and your existence, and how you got to live in a sleepy suburban town an hour away from a thriving metropolitan area that you and your husband will visit once a month to look for nice apartments you both know you will never be able to afford. By 50, you will begin to consider opening up a small business, but by 60, you realize this dream is no longer attainable. The amount of debt you are in from sending your little dufflings to college has buried you so deep in financial distress you consider hiring a man to kill your husband for his life insurance. After finding your "zen", a class you paid for at the local YMCA, you will convince yourself that life and money are meaningless, and these truths we must accept in order to live our lives to the full. Sadly, by this point, your

life is over. You are dying because of a food poisoning you contracted from a box of expired Cheez-its, and all of your children are unsuccessful and alone.

EUNICE

So that's it?

SELF-ESTEEM

Look, Eunice. I like you, I really do. I am you. However, I am constantly buried in the negativity you allow to seep through to your brain and your heart. I don't want this boy to make that even worse for you. Do you want me completely gone? Do you want that life that I outlined for you? You need me. I know your dreams. Your dream isn't suburban life, a minimum-wage job, a duff husband. But right now, you think you deserve those things.

EUNICE

But I don't want those things! I don't want those things! I don't

want--

TED shakes EUNICE awake, who has blacked out on the football field.

TED

Eunice! Wake up! You blacked out!

EUNICE

What? Huh?

TED

Eunice? Are you okay? Should I call the nurse or something?

EUNICE

No, I'm good. After those 12 crayons, my body can handle anything.

EUNICE is wobbly, loosing her balance.

TED

You sure about that?

TED and EUNICE both laugh together. EUNICE takes off her helmet, and shakes out her hair.

TED

(in shock)

... whoaaa, Eunice is that you? You look so hot right now.

EUNICE

Really? I feel pretty gross. I mean I got this awful foot fungus on my toe the other day and--

TED

(laughing)

You're funny.

EUNICE

(looking off to the side)

Well, I was being serious but..

TED

You wanna go grab fro-yo? You might need to replenish your electrolysis..

EUNICE

(wobbling)

..I think you mean electrolytes..

but you're probably right. Let's

go!

TED

(looks around)

Could you just do me a favor and

not mention this to any of my

friends?

EUNICE

Since when do I talk to any of your

friends?

TED

Well, I mean.. you guys have

nicknames for each other..

EUNICE

Just because they call me Eu-nice

Bowels doesn't mean we're on a path

to a wonderful friendship.

TED

Well, just don't mention it to any

of them, please.

EUNICE

Are you embarrassed of me?

TED

What? No! I just don't want to mess up the social "hi-marchy".

EUNICE

Its hierarchy.

TED

How would you know? You're at the bottom of it, Eunice.

EUNICE

Well, just a second ago I thought we were having a moment!

TED

A moment? I mean, yeah. I guess so. But that doesn't mean we have to announce it to the whole world.

EUNICE

Well, when did I say I wanted to announce it to the whole world? I don't have good social skills!

TED

Well, I still want to hang out. You're cool. And you're not like other girls.

EUNICE

Sorry, Ted. But I can't hang out with you. I wouldn't want to upset your reputation. I'm a duff, remember?

EUNICE steps out of the scene, and reflects.

EUNICE

As I walked away that day, I learned a few things. One, I cannot play football. Two, I should really see a doctor about my toe. But most importantly, I learned that my self-worth isn't dependent on other people's affirmation of who I am. True, Ted's hot. But, Ted is also pretty stupid, and although I appreciate his friendship, I'm just not looking for a boyfriend right now.

TED

(raising arms)

I never even asked you out! We

we're just going to get fro-yo!

EUNICE

What are you doing in my

self-reflection, Ted? Get out!

TED walks away.

SELF-ESTEEM

(yelling, jovial, bigger than

ever, different accent, New

York or Christopher Walken or

something.)

Eunice! I'm so proud of you!

EUNICE

(scared)

Who is that?

SELF-ESTEEM

Its me! You. I'm your self-esteem.

A little bigger, a little stronger.

True, the doctor told me my BMI is

very unhealthy. Probably because I

doubled in size in the past hour!

I'm so proud of you!

EUNICE

Well, why do you sound so different

than before?

SELF-ESTEEM

This is just how your

sub-conscience perceives a strong,

independent woman.

EUNICE

Oh.. makes sense. I need to stop

watching so many Tyler Perry

movies.

SELF-ESTEEM

(laughing)

Ha-ha-ha, Eunice. You crack me up.

I crack me up. We're cracking each

other up!

EUNICE

Am I on crack?

SELF-ESTEEM

It doesn't matter. It's all the same! After those 12 crayons--

EUNICE

--okaywereallyneedtostopremindingpeopleaboutthose12crayons--

SELF-ESTEEM

Eunice, your future is so bright, I wish I hadn't sat on those sunglasses that someone left on my seat on the bus I had to take over here.

EUNICE

You had to take a bus over here? How does that even work?

SELF-ESTEEM

(flicking it away)

It doesn't matter. We are on a road to a wonderful life, my friend! Full of ups and downs, mountains and valleys, more mountains and that one really deep valley that you think you'll never be able to

climb out of-- But don't worry! You

get out of it! You find your

climbing shoes and you never look

down!

EUNICE

Watch out, world! Here comes

Eu-nice Bowels!